Question Paper Formatting Guide

A simple guide for preparing your paper in our standard format.

Thank you for preparing your paper in this format. Typing it in a clear, consistent way helps it move through review and reach students much faster, with far fewer corrections needed afterwards. Everything below can be done in ordinary Microsoft Word – no special software needed.

1. Start with these lines

At the very top of your paper, write these lines, in this order: subject, grade and title always; teacher and duration whenever they apply.

```
Subject: Combined Mathematics
Grade: 12
Title: First Term Test
Teacher: Mr. A. Perera
Duration: 150 minutes
Difficulty Level: Medium
```

Write the duration as a single figure in one unit – "150 minutes" rather than "2 hours 30 minutes" – so it is clear at a glance.

2. If your paper has more than one part

Give each part its own line, on its own, with nothing else written on that line:

```
Part I – Multiple Choice Questions (40 marks)
Part II – Structured Questions
```

Keep a part heading short and on its own line – don't continue a sentence after it.

3. Instructions for each part

Write any instructions for a part directly under its heading, on their own line or two, before the first question – for example, how many questions to answer, or what kind of question the part contains.

If every question in a part carries the same marks, say so plainly:

```
Part II – Structured Questions
Each question carries 15 marks.
```

If students only need to answer some of the questions, say exactly how many – for example "Answer four questions only" or "Answer any 5 questions", not just "Answer some questions". For a multiple-choice part, a plain phrase such as "Choose the correct answer" or "Select the correct answer" makes the part clear.

4. Number every question the same way

Use the same numbering style for every question in the paper – always "1. 2. 3." and so on. Do not switch to "Q4" or "(5)" partway through.

Write each question's marks in square brackets at the end:

```
1. Explain the process of photosynthesis.                    [10]
```

Never skip a number or repeat one – keep counting up without any gaps. If a question expects an answer in a particular unit, state it in the question itself, such as "Calculate the current, in amperes.", rather than leaving the unit to be assumed. If your school also records a difficulty level for each question, write it in brackets after the marks, such as "[10] [Medium]".

If you want each question to show which topic or unit of the syllabus it comes from, add that in brackets too, right after the marks – the same way as the difficulty level above. For a multiple-choice question, put it right after the question itself, before the options:

```
5. Explain the process of photosynthesis.   [10] [Topic: Photosynthesis]

3. Which gas causes the greenhouse effect?  [Topic: Environmental Science]
(1) Nitrogen
(2) Oxygen
(3) Carbon dioxide
(4) Argon
```

5. Multiple choice questions

Pick one style for your options and use it for every multiple-choice question in the paper – either "(1) (2) (3) (4)" or "A. B. C. D.", not a mix of both. Put each option on its own line.

```
3. Which gas is most responsible for the greenhouse effect?
(1) Nitrogen
(2) Oxygen
(3) Carbon dioxide
(4) Argon
```

6. Questions with several parts

Use lower-case letters for parts of a question: (a) (b) (c). If a part has its own smaller parts, use (i) (ii) (iii) underneath it. Give each part its own marks.

```
5. A school library uses a computerized system to manage its records.
(a) Define the term "system" as used in computing.              [2]
(b) Draw a fully labelled block diagram of the system.           [5]
```

7. Fill-in-the-blank questions

Number each blank space, so we know which answer belongs to which gap:

```
7. He walked (1) ______ (across / through / around) the field before the match.
```

8. Diagrams, graphs and equations

Please type out all of the words in your question. Insert a picture only for the diagram, graph or equation itself – never a photo or screenshot of a question that includes writing. A typed sentence always comes through clearly; a photo of a sentence often does not.

9. Maths and Science equations

For maths, physics, chemistry, applied maths and pure maths papers, equations need one extra step: use Word's built-in Equation Editor (Insert -> Equation) for every formula, fraction, square root or chemical equilibrium arrow, rather than typing special symbols by hand or pasting a picture of one.

Ordinary subscripts and superscripts for chemical formulas (H2O, CO2, x2) are fine typed normally, using Word's subscript/superscript button – these come through clearly as plain text.

Why this matters: a formula typed with Word's Equation Editor comes through correctly every time. A screenshot or photo of an equation – even a neatly typed one – often comes out with its symbols damaged or wrong, and a handwritten equation is very often not readable at all.

10. Your marking scheme

Put your marking scheme in its own section at the very end of the paper, starting with the heading "MARKING SCHEME" in capital letters on its own line. Label every answer exactly the way you labelled its question.

```
MARKING SCHEME

1. (3)
2. (2)

5. (a) Definition of a system                                    [2 marks]
   A system is an organized collection of interacting
   components.
   (b) Diagram showing input, process, output and
   feedback loop.                                                 [5 marks]
```

11. A few things to avoid

- Don't mix numbering styles in the same paper.
- Don't leave a part's instructions vague, such as "Answer some questions" – say exactly how many.
- Don't paste a photo or screenshot of a question if you can type it instead.
- Don't type an equation using plain-text symbols or paste it as a picture – use Word's Equation Editor.
- Don't leave your marking scheme without the "MARKING SCHEME" heading.
- Don't skip or repeat a question number.
- **Sinhala**: "Iskoola Pota" (built into Windows already) or "Noto Sans Sinhala"
- **Tamil**: "Latha" (built into Windows already) or "Noto Sans Tamil"
- **English**: Any font

Following this guide takes no extra time – it simply means typing your paper consistently. It helps your paper reach students faster, with fewer corrections needed afterwards. Thank you!